The AI Readiness Checklist

Twelve questions every leadership team should be able to answer about the AI already running in their business.

Most organisations don't have an AI problem so much as a visibility problem: AI is already in use somewhere in the business, and nobody has a complete, accurate picture of where. This isn't a compliance audit, it's a starting point. Work through each question directly, in the room with whoever actually knows the answer.

Visibility

1. Do you have a complete, accurate list of every AI tool in use across the business, including tools nobody officially approved?

Policy & ownership

2. Is there a written acceptable-use policy, and could most staff describe what it actually says?
3. Is there a named person accountable for AI risk, or does everyone assume it's someone else's job?
4. For every AI-assisted decision that affects a customer, is it clear when a human has to be in the loop?

Third parties

5. For every AI-enabled tool you've bought in, do you know what the vendor does with your data?

Regulation

6. Could someone in your business state, in one sentence, whether the EU AI Act or UK GDPR applies to what you're doing with AI?

Evidence & audit

7. If a customer sent you a due-diligence questionnaire about your AI use tomorrow, could you answer it from documents you already hold?
8. Could you show, with evidence, how a specific AI-assisted decision was actually made?

Readiness

9. If an AI system produced a harmful or wrong output tomorrow, is there a known process for what happens next?
10. Has anyone actually been trained on what the policy requires of them, or does it exist only as a document?
11. Could your board describe your organisation's AI risk exposure in one sentence, right now?
12. Is anyone responsible for revisiting this list as your AI use changes?

Scoring: if you answered “no” or “not sure” to more than three or four of these, that's not unusual, and it isn't a compliance failure. It's the normal starting position for an organisation that hasn't yet mapped its own AI use, and it's exactly the gap a short discovery engagement is built to close.

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